

AFRICAN UNION

الاتحاد الأفريقي

UMOJA WA AFRIKA



UNION AFRICAINE

UNIÃO AFRICANA

UNIÓN AFRICANA

DEPARTMENT OF EDUCATION, SCIENCE, TECHNOLOGY, AND INNOVATION

CALL FOR CONSULTANCY SERVICES

Development of a Continental Early Childhood Education and Development (ECED) Framework for Africa

African Union Commission (AUC)

TERMS OF REFERENCE (ToR)

Background and Rational: Early Childhood Education and Development (ECED) is widely recognized as the foundation for lifelong learning, human capital development, and socio-economic transformation. Evidence consistently demonstrates that investments in early childhood yield some of the highest returns in education systems, improving learning outcomes, health, social cohesion, and productivity throughout the life course. Across Africa, however, access to quality ECED services remains uneven. While several Member States have adopted national early childhood policies and programmes, significant disparities persist in access, quality, financing, teacher preparation, curriculum standards, and governance structures. Many countries also face challenges related to:

- Fragmented policy frameworks and institutional coordination.
- Insufficient investment and sustainable financing mechanisms.
- Limited professional standards and training pathways for ECED educators.
- Weak monitoring systems and data availability.
- Inequities affecting children in rural areas, conflict-affected settings, and vulnerable communities.

The Continental Education Strategy for Africa (CESA 2026–2035) recognizes early childhood development as a critical entry point for improving foundational learning and strengthening education systems across the continent. In parallel, the AU Decade of Education and Skills Development (2025–2034) emphasizes building strong learning foundations and strengthening human capital development pathways across the life cycle. In this context, the African Union Commission (AUC), through the Department of Education, Science, Technology and Innovation (ESTI), in collaboration with the African Early Childhood Network (AfECN), seeks to develop a Continental Early Childhood Education and Development (ECED) Framework to guide Member States, Regional Economic Communities (RECs), and partners in strengthening early childhood systems across Africa.

The framework will provide continental policy guidance, standards, and strategic priorities to support Member States in designing and implementing integrated, inclusive, and high-quality ECED systems aligned with CESA 26–35 and Agenda 2063 aspirations.

To support this process, the African Union Commission seeks to engage a qualified consultant (or consultancy firm) to lead the development of the Continental ECED Framework through a consultative and evidence-based process.

Objective of the Consultancy: The overall objective of the consultancy is to develop a comprehensive Continental Early Childhood Education and Development (ECED) Framework for Africa that provides strategic guidance, standards, and implementation pathways to support Member States in strengthening early childhood education systems in alignment with CESA 2026–2035 and the AU Decade of Education and Skills Development (2025–2034).

Specific Objectives: The consultancy will aim to:

- a) Conduct a comprehensive situational analysis of ECED policies, systems, and practices across AU Member States to identify:
 - i. Key challenges, gaps, and opportunities in ECED policy implementation and service delivery.
 - ii. Capacity gaps and propose a capacity development strategy for policymakers, educators, and institutions to support effective implementation
 - iii. Knowledge gaps and propose mechanisms for knowledge sharing, peer learning, and documentation of good practices across AU Member States.
 - iv. Risks and propose mitigation strategies to address potential barriers to implementation
 - v. Opportunities for digital innovation and technology in strengthening ECED delivery, monitoring, and teacher development
- b) Review global and regional ECED frameworks, standards, and best practices relevant to the African context.
- c) Develop a continental ECED policy and strategic framework that supports Member States in strengthening early childhood systems.
- d) Propose guidelines, standards, and implementation mechanisms for effective ECED delivery.
- e) Provide monitoring indicators aligned with CESA 26–35 results frameworks and SDG 4 targets.
- f) Facilitate consultations with Member States, RECs, development partners, and key stakeholders to ensure broad ownership and validation of the framework.

Scope of Work: The consultant will undertake the following key tasks:

- i. **Situational and Policy Analysis**
 - Review ECED policies, strategies, and institutional arrangements across AU Member States.
 - Analyze regional and continental initiatives related to early childhood development.
 - Identify systemic gaps in access, quality, governance, financing, workforce development, and monitoring systems.

- Assess key implementation challenges, capacity and knowledge gaps, risks and mitigation strategies, and opportunities for digital innovation, peer learning, and strengthened service delivery
- ii. **Benchmarking and Evidence Review**
- Review global ECED frameworks and standards including relevant UNESCO, UNICEF, World Bank, and international best practices.
 - Identify adaptable models and innovations relevant to African education systems.
- iii. **Development of the Continental ECED Framework:** Develop a comprehensive framework that includes:
- Vision and strategic objectives for ECED in Africa.
 - Policy principles and guiding values.
 - Institutional coordination mechanisms.
 - Standards for quality ECED provision.
 - Teacher training and professional development guidelines.
 - Capacity development strategy for policymakers and institutions to support effective implementation
 - Mitigation strategies to address potential barriers to implementation
 - Research agenda to guide evidence generation, address knowledge gaps, and inform policy and practice across AU Member States.
 - Curriculum and pedagogical guidance.
 - Financing strategies for ECED systems.
 - Governance and accountability mechanisms.
 - Inclusion strategies for marginalized and vulnerable children.
 - Monitoring, evaluation, and data systems.
- iv. **Stakeholder Consultations**
- Organize and facilitate consultative engagements with Member States, RECs, and technical partners.
 - Incorporate feedback from stakeholders into the framework.
- v. **Validation and Finalization**
- Support the organization of a continental validation workshop.
 - Revise the framework based on technical feedback and validation outcomes.

Key Deliverables: The consultant will deliver the following outputs:

- a) Inception Report outlining methodology, workplan, and analytical framework.
- b) Situational Analysis Report on ECED in Africa.
- c) Draft Continental ECED Framework.
- d) Stakeholder Consultation Summary Report.
- e) Revised ECED Framework incorporating stakeholder inputs.
- f) Final Continental ECED Framework for Africa ready for policy adoption and dissemination.

Anticipated Schedule: The following is the anticipated schedule for this assignment. Please note that dates are tentative and subject to adjustment.

#	Phase	Key Deliverable	Timeline
1	Recruitment	Selection and contracting consultant	May 2026
2	Framework Development	First draft Framework reviewed and approved by AUC for validation	August 2026
3	Member States Consultation	Compile and integrate AU Member State comments into document	September 2026
4	Online Validation Workshop	Presentation of the Framework at AUC validation workshop	October 2026
5	Finalisation of the Framework	Final Framework produced by consultant and signed off by AUC	October 2026

Duration of the Assignment: The consultancy is expected to be conducted over a period of 90 working days within six (6) months from the date of contract signature.

Institutional Arrangements: The consultant will work under the overall supervision of the African Union Commission – Department of Education, Science, Technology and Innovation (ESTI). Technical coordination will be undertaken in collaboration with: The African Early Childhood Network (AfECN), Relevant CESA Clusters, AU Member States, Regional Economic Communities (RECs) and Development partners and technical institutions.

Required Qualifications and Experience: The consultant should possess the following qualifications:

- i. **Academic Qualifications**
 - Advanced degree (Master’s or PhD) in Education, Early Childhood Development, Education Policy, Social Policy, or related field.
- ii. **Professional Experience**
 - Minimum 10 years of experience in education policy, early childhood development, or education system strengthening.
 - Demonstrated experience in developing policy frameworks, strategies, or continental guidelines.
 - Strong knowledge of African education systems and policy environments.
 - Experience working with regional or international organizations is highly desirable.
- iii. **Competencies**
 - Strong research and analytical skills.
 - Proven experience in policy writing and strategic frameworks.

- Excellent stakeholder engagement and consultation skills.
- Strong written and communication skills in English (knowledge of French is an asset).

Application Requirements: Interested candidates should submit the following to AU:

- i. A technical proposal outlining the approach and methodology.
- ii. A detailed workplan and timeline.
- iii. Curriculum Vitae (CV) highlighting relevant experience.
- iv. Examples of previous similar assignments or publications.
- v. A financial proposal indicating consultancy fees.

Evaluation Criteria: Applications will be evaluated based on:

- Relevant professional experience and expertise.
- Quality of the proposed methodology.
- Demonstrated experience in similar assignments.
- Cost-effectiveness of the financial proposal.
- Alignment with CESA 2026–2035 priorities and Agenda 2063 aspirations.

All applications should be submitted to hr@afecn.org by COB 17th April 2026